



MONTHLY UPDATE

Ethiopia: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-08 • 38 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH • GOVERNANCE • FINANCE • ICT INFRASTRUCTURE • DPI • CAPACITY • INCLUSION • GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

The identity system is now most of the state's digital surface. Fayda [neared 50 million enrolments](#), the programme was inaugurated as a state-owned enterprise under the sovereign wealth fund on 4 August, and its wallet is being extended beyond core government credentials. A public critique [set out the absence of independent data-protection safeguards over it](#), which is the position the base holds on the other side of that expansion.

Three instruments and one build moved alongside. The Critical Infrastructure Cybersecurity Proclamation [was signed, designating twelve critical sectors and placing eighteen obligations on owners and operators, commencing about a year after gazettment](#); a Berne Convention ratification draft went to the Council of Ministers alongside an online-infringement amendment to the 2004 copyright proclamation; and the incumbent entered active deployment of a terrestrial fibre corridor from Djibouti through Ethiopia and Sudan to Jeddah. The unified public-service platform [now lists more than 180 services from 23 organisations](#).

Governance

Legislation and regulation

Three instruments moved in the window and none binds yet. The Critical Infrastructure Cybersecurity Proclamation [was signed by the President at Addis Ababa on 21 July, designating twelve critical sectors, placing eighteen core obligations on owners and operators and creating a cybersecurity fund](#), with commencement set one year after gazettment “about July 2027” and regulation-making powers left to the Council of Ministers and the security agency. On copyright, a [draft ratification proclamation for the Berne Convention went to the Council of Ministers, and a separate amendment to the 2004 copyright proclamation is being drafted with a university law school to add internet service provider duties, site-blocking procedures and a rights-holder take-down notice](#). Ethiopia is not yet a party to the convention and neither draft has a published text.

Data protection

The Development Bank [adopted an information disclosure policy classifying client credit information permanently non-disclosable](#), alongside legal case files, strategy papers, security protocols and third-party contracts, where disclosure could cause substantial harm to the Bank, its stakeholders or the national interest. The Bank may also decline a request that would require it to create a record it does not already hold. No instrument number, gazette reference or appeal mechanism is stated.

Two further positions sit beside it. A public critique [set out the absence of independent data-protection safeguards over the national digital identity](#), which this ledger records as not held. And the foreign ministry [circulated a diplomatic note asking missions for staff and property records](#), with no legal basis, retention period or purpose limitation stated for the collection.

Regional collaboration

The regional transit corridor moved from agreement to build. Ethio telecom [entered active deployment of the Horizon Fiber Initiative, with end-to-end solution architecture finalised and site-material procurement complete](#), on a multi-terabit terrestrial route linking Djibouti's subsea landings through Ethiopia and Sudan to Jeddah. No route length, capacity, cost, in-service date or transit-revenue projection is published, so the regional-hub claim rests on the geography alone — and one of the four territories the route crosses is at war.

Standards

A standing readiness instrument the base had not held was named from practice rather than from the regulator. A practitioner's case is that a [central bank microfinance directive of 2022 already defines the governance, risk-management and operational readiness that institutions skip when they buy digital wallets before building the capability to run them](#). The directive text is not held and no supervisory finding, enforcement action or compliance count is published, so what the base has is the rule's existence and one account of how it is being ignored.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

A project on [climate-change disinformation and information integrity across African digital environments launched in August 2026, focused on Uganda and Ethiopia and supported by a UNESCO-led global initiative](#). It combines research mapping how climate disinformation spreads and who drives it with a fact-checking masterclass at the 2026 internet-freedom forum, online training for journalists and civil society, and tracking of African governments' communications ahead of the November 2026 climate conference. No budget or duration is stated.

Finance

New investments

The month's finance entry is an allegation rather than a commitment. Corruption allegations against a donor-funded digital project [were raised in the German federal parliament](#). No project name, amount, Ethiopian response or investigation outcome is on the record held, so what the base carries is that the question has been asked in a donor's own legislature.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The incumbent closed its financial year with [data and internet at 31.1% of revenue against mobile voice at 23.5%](#) — the first year in which voice was not the largest share — on 215.8bn Birr of revenue and 92.9bn Birr of operating profit, the operator's own unaudited figures. Build-out continued underneath it: a progress review on 10 August put [879 sites completed under one vendor programme and 4G population coverage at 92%](#), a figure scoped to that vendor's own footprint and not reconciled against the 95.5% national coverage claimed for the wider contract set. The second licensee reported [14.7 million ninety-day active customers at 30 June](#), against a target of positive earnings by March 2027.

Energy

The incumbent's renewable programme reached [39.72 MW of installed solar across 190 fully solar-powered sites, 867 hybrid systems and 1,114 lithium-ion storage units](#), 12.72 MW of it added over the financial year, with diesel generator running time down by up to 40%. The figures are the operator's own and unaudited.

DPI

Data Exchange

A delegation joined the [UNDP Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure's session of 2-3 September](#) alongside Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia, on moving digital public infrastructure blueprints to execution, verifiable credentials and consented data sharing, and reusable open-source deployment code. Attendance and a [published agenda](#) are the whole of what is established; nothing on the record commits the country to a programme.

Digital Identity and CRVS

The identity programme supplied most of the month's movement: a [joint venture with Safaricom and a local partner](#) on 6 July to run mass registration across seven regions, and, on 24 July, the operator's own disclosure that it accounts for 69% of all registrations, with more than 4m farmers enrolled through the agriculture ministry and more than 28,000 displaced people through humanitarian partners.

At the same 24 July launch of a three-year strategic plan, its deputy director in the capital named premature integration as the year's main obstacle and its founding director general conceded the platform remains intertwined with decades-old institutional systems of undefined standards. The identity layer meanwhile acquired a corporate owner: the Faydaverse digital-public-infrastructure enterprise was inaugurated on 4 August as a state-owned enterprise under Ethiopian Investment Holdings, on a platform [reported at over 190 million authentications performed and 150 enterprises integrated for biometric checks](#). No governing instrument, board or commercial model for the enterprise is published.

Four days later that enterprise set out where the credential goes next. Its wallet is [to carry academic transcripts, professional licences, healthcare records, property titles and financial-compliance and know-your-customer data beyond the core government credentials it holds today](#), and the enterprise says it is exporting identity services as an implementation partner in Mozambique and Zambia. The plan and the export claims are its own; no timetable, consent model, data-controller arrangement or regulatory approval for the additional credential types is stated.

Enrolment passed a further mark at the close of the period. The programme [put registrations at 49.1m on 24 August, on 12,000 biometric registration kits deployed and 150 agencies integrated, with more than 194m eKYC verifications performed against the register](#). The counts are the programme's own and unaudited, and the [prime-ministerial expectation that the credential will contribute 7% of GDP by 2030](#) is stated alongside them as a projection rather than a measurement. The reporting outlet's "90 million by 2027" is its own framing: the programme's target is 90m by 2028.

What is not on the record is the counterweight. A published critique argues the system [risks becoming an instrument of mass profiling in the absence of independent data-protection impact assessments, meaningful citizen rights and legal limits on state access](#), against the registrations above, up from 16.4m in June 2025, and a 90m target. The base holds no such assessment, no redress mechanism and no statutory access limit, and that absence is now recorded as a gap.

The enrolment rules reached the base for the first time, which matters more than the enrolment count for anyone trying to work out who can be enrolled. The programme's own page lists [33 accepted proof-of-identity documents, from the local administration card and passport to birth, education, marriage and business records](#), and a separate account sets out what non-citizens must present: [an origin card and passport for foreign nationals of Ethiopian origin, a residence or work permit plus passport for other foreign residents, and a valid refugee card for recognised refugees](#). Neither carries its own issue date, so both are dated to capture — and the refugee route stated here is the operative counterpart to the refugee-inclusion framework the base already holds.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Payments extended into utilities and tax. Prepaid electricity purchase entered the mobile-money super app on 29 July for smart-meter customers, and a digital tax-payment service for one regional revenue bureau launched on 28 July as the first of a planned series.

The market also drew a new foreign supplier. A South African financial-technology firm [entered the Ethiopian payments market with a local engineering partner on 17 August](#), aligning onboarding, fraud-management and workflow-automation tools with the National Digital Payments Strategy 2026-2030. No commitment value, customer or deployment date is disclosed.

Federal authorities began [testing whether a single payment window can serve the whole government, starting with health](#). No transaction volume, participating-institution list or rollout timetable accompanies the pilot.

Sectoral management information systems

A [livestock information system went live on 29 July](#), drawing on five priority databases and repositioning animal identification from an export tool to a national asset register — broadened from feedlots to farm level and linked to disease surveillance and vaccination records. The account is the implementer's own, written after four years with a team embedded in the ministry, and is uncorroborated here. A system that has been running far longer got its evaluation: a journal study published on 10 August [puts a community HIV case-management application in the hands of 950 health workers, with the time to reach case data down from a month to a day and data completeness near 100%. Ninety-two per cent of mobile accounts and 94% of web accounts were actively used](#). The figures are the study's and cover deployment since 2017; no national coverage figure or cost is given.

A technology group and a bank [signed an agreement to digitise the agricultural supply chain](#); no scope, value, farmer count or launch date is stated.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The unified public-service platform launched with [185 services against 41 across twelve federal agencies a year earlier](#), anchored on the national identity credential. An account of 13 August puts the platform at [more than 2,200 services](#), on the occasion of a Beninese benchmarking visit; the base cannot reconcile that with the launch count two months earlier and the two may rest on different counting bases. Its own regional executives say [services are being onboarded before the systems beneath them are digitised](#), that two incompatible integration models have emerged, that no legal framework compels an institution to digitise before joining, and that the platform ran close to a year with no dedicated regulatory framework. Separately the Auditor General's annual report, presented on 6 July, [credits electronic procurement with the decline in cash shortages across 163 audited federal institutions](#) while finding budget-execution gaps, billions of Birr uncollected and repeated financial-rule violations alongside the digital adoption. No Birr amount is attached to the credit, and the report itself is not held.

A service portal was built inside an agency rather than procured. The commodity exchange [launched one using its own information-technology staff, replacing in-person visits to offices that drew more than 150 callers a day in peak season with a stated thirty-minute service-level target](#). Both figures are the exchange's own, and no user count, service list or measured turnaround is published — but an in-house build is a different capability claim from a procurement, and it is the first of its kind the base holds here.

Capacity

Training and skills

The flagship coder-training programme is [now reported as a seven million coders initiative](#), a target raised from the five million the digital transformation council had been working to. The raise is reported rather than gazetted, and no enrolment, completion or certification figure accompanies it.

Research institutions

University connectivity is the delivery side of the research position. A funder's account [describes campus connectivity transforming learning across Ethiopian campuses](#). It is the funder's own account, with no bandwidth, campus count or student figure in the record held.

Against it the FY2026/27 federal budget [carries Artificial Intelligence University Construction as a single named capital project at ETB 5,000,000,000](#) — domestic money, appropriated rather than pledged, and large enough to dominate the year's digital total on its own. Nothing moved on the national artificial-intelligence policy itself, on model development, or on which foundation models the country runs.

Inclusion

Access to services

The month's movement on access is participation rather than service. The National Dialogue Commission [reports that its conference ran from 15 July to 22 August 2026, with around 4,000 participants deliberating eight national agenda items and recommendations submitted to the Commission](#). It is the Commission's own account, and nothing in the record held states which recommendations were taken up. Nothing moved this month on digital access to public services, on refugee inclusion or on device affordability.

The corridor programme put training against formalisation rather than connectivity. [Forty women traders took export-readiness training at Bishoftu on 30 and 31 July 2026 under a EUR 32m European corridor programme, covering business formalisation, product standards, export documentation and customs procedure, against a stated 94% of the traders concerned operating unlicensed](#). That 94% is the programme's characterisation of its own target group rather than a national measure, and no digital component of the corridor programme is separately costed.

Geopolitics

India activities

India enters the record as a destination rather than a donor. Senior officials from the digital and ICT sector and line ministries [joined delegations from four other African states and the African Union Commission on a south-south learning mission hosted by the United Nations Development Programme](#), studying India's digital public infrastructure and the institutions that built it; [the state government of Karnataka received them in Bengaluru on 1 September](#). No agreement, financing, technology transfer or follow-on commitment is named on either side.

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